

ANKLE SPRAIN

TIPS & STRETCHES TO HELP YOU FEEL BETTER



Ankle sprains occur when the ligaments that support your ankle stretch or tear.

These tips and exercises can help reduce pain, restore movement, and prevent future sprains.



PROTECT, REST, ICE, COMPRESS, ELEVATE

Protect your ankle and avoid activities that increase pain.

Ice for 15–20 minutes, 2–3 times per day for the first 48–72 hours.

Use compression and elevate to reduce swelling.



USE SUPPORT

Wear a supportive brace or wrap as needed.

Use crutches if recommended by your provider.



GRADUALLY RETURN TO ACTIVITY

Increase activity slowly and as pain allows.

Stop if your pain increases or swelling returns.



FOCUS ON STRENGTH & BALANCE

Strengthening and balance exercises help restore stability and prevent future sprains.



WEAR PROPER FOOTWEAR

Wear supportive shoes that fit well.

Avoid uneven surfaces during recovery.



LISTEN TO YOUR BODY

Mild soreness is normal. Sharp pain, instability, or increased swelling means you may be doing too much.



BE PATIENT & CONSISTENT

Healing takes time. Consistent exercises improve strength, flexibility, and stability for a full recovery.

WHEN TO SEEK CARE

Seek medical attention if you experience:

- Inability to bear weight
- Severe pain or swelling
- Numbness, tingling, or discoloration
- Instability that does not improve
- Pain that worsens or does not improve within a few days



It's normal for swelling and bruising to last 1–2 weeks or longer. Keep working on your exercises!

GENTLE EXERCISES FOR ANKLE SPRAIN

1 ABC'S OF THE ANKLE



- Sit or lie down with your leg supported and heel off the ground.
- Slowly trace the alphabet in the air with your toes.
- Move through the full alphabet.
- Repeat 1–2 times daily.

2 TOWEL SCRUNCH



- Sit in a chair with a towel on the floor.
- Use your toes to scrunch the towel toward you.
- Slowly release and repeat.
- Do for 1–2 minutes.

3 CALF STRETCH



- Stand facing a wall with one foot back.
- Keep your back leg straight and heel on the ground.
- Lean forward until you feel a stretch in your calf.
- Hold for 20–30 seconds.
- Repeat 2–3 times each leg.

4 SINGLE LEG BALANCE



- Stand on your injured leg.
- Keep your knee slightly bent and core engaged.
- Hold for 20–30 seconds.
- Repeat 2–3 times.
- Progress by closing your eyes or standing on an uneven surface.



Mild discomfort is normal, but exercises should not cause sharp pain. Stop if pain or swelling increases and consult a healthcare provider.

IF YOUR SYMPTOMS PERSIST OR WORSEN, PLEASE FOLLOW UP WITH YOUR PROVIDER.

This handout is for educational purposes only and is not a substitute for professional medical advice.

Always consult your healthcare provider with any questions or concerns.